

know of the news that NASA was getting ready for its first sub-orbital flight in 1961, so they decided to aim higher (literally) and be the first to send a man into Earth's orbit.

After the success of Sputnik 5, they conducted one last test of the Vostok 3KA rocket in which they sent a dummy, along with a dog, into orbit on an unmanned spacecraft that would be identical to the one they use for sending their first cosmonaut into space. Launched on March 9, 1961, the mission was a success as the rocket left the earth, entered orbit, and left that to re-enter Earth, following which the mannequin was safely ejected and the dog recovered in a detached descent module.

Finally, every go-ahead was given and the Soviets were ready to launch their first man into space. Colonel Yuri Gagarin was chosen for this prestigious mission – which, surprisingly, would also be his last space mission. On April 12, 1961, the era of human spaceflight began. The rocket lifted off – Gagarin yelling over the ride, “Let’s ride!” – and the cosmonaut became the first human to orbit the Earth in his Vostok I spacecraft.

This was the first spacecraft to carry a human into space, occurring 25 days prior to the first US suborbital flight. Because of concerns of adverse reactions to due to experiencing weightlessness, the manual controls on the spacecraft were locked prior to launch and the entire flight was under the control of ground personnel. Gagarin, however, had the option of being able to manually control the flight if deemed absolutely necessary.

The spacecraft consisted of a nearly spherical cabin covered with ablative material. There were three small portholes and external radio antennas. Radios, a life support system, instrumentation, and an ejection seat were contained in the manned cabin. This cabin was attached to a service module that carried chemical batteries, orientation rockets, the main retro system, and added support equipment for the total system. This module was separated from the manned cabin on re-entry. After one orbit, the spacecraft



A model of the Vostok I spacecraft